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Washington County

Going nowhere

McDonald seeks cyclists, but Panhandle Trail remains disconnected

Sunday, May 25, 2003

By Joe Smydo, Post-Gazette Staff Writer

Dedicated in 1999 and described as the first segment of Washington County's "linear park," the six-tenths-of-a-mile stretch of Panhandle Trail outside McDonald remains a path to nowhere.

In four years there's been no further construction of the 17.3-mile recreational trail in the county, distressing not only trail enthusiasts but those who see the Panhandle as a way to lure visitors to McDonald's languishing business district. To hear some talk, the project has been held hostage by those who should be working hardest to stimulate economic growth -- the county commissioners.

"Anybody and everybody at Courthouse Square will tell you that the delay is because of the infighting among the commissioners," Tim Thomassy, a member of McDonald Area Redevelopment Association, said in an e-mail to the Pittsburgh Post-Gazette.

Anticipating the Panhandle's construction this year, the redevelopment association purchased the former Kio's Colonial Lounge Restaurant along the old railroad bed and converted it into a trail station and community meeting house, a \$100,000 project.

At the building's grand opening from 2 to 5 p.m. next Sunday, the group should have plenty of brochures publicizing McDonald's businesses. Bicycle racks have been placed around town. Only the trail will be lacking.

Commissioners Chairman John P. Bevec and Commissioner Diana L. Irely said construction of the trail -- from McDonald west to Robinson, then to Burgettstown and the state line -- has been hampered by technical issues but not infighting.

"I support it," Bevec said.

"I've made it known that I support the project," Irely said.

But Commissioner J. Bracken Burns, who spearheaded the project while board chairman during the last term, said Thomassy's suspicions are correct.

Burns said Bevec and Irely have stalled the project to slight him, McDonald's welfare be damned. Moreover, Burns said former parks and recreation director Andy Baechle, well respected in the trail community, lost his job in December 2001 because he was caught in the crossfire.

"It's not going forward because it's my project. That's my baby," said Burns, at odds with Bevec and Irely since they stripped him of the chairmanship in January 2000.

Overall, planning director Lisa Cessna said, work on the trail is about a year behind schedule. But, she said, she hopes to cobble together a plan and begin work this year on a mile-plus portion of trail in and around McDonald.

If that doesn't happen, Burns soon may be in a position to crack the whip.

Burns and his running mate, Sheriff Larry Maggi, unseated Bevec in Tuesday's Democratic primary. The pair will face Irely and businessman Lou Waller Sr., the Republican nominees, in November. Three of the four will make up the next board of commissioners.

The county has about \$2 million for construction -- not enough to complete the trail but enough for a significant portion, officials said.

Until the 1970s, the Panhandle was a Pennsylvania Railroad line linking Pittsburgh with Cincinnati, Chicago and St. Louis. After five years of negotiation, Conrail in 1999 donated 29 miles of railroad bed to Washington County, Allegheny County and West Virginia.

Allegheny County's section of trail, about 7 miles from Collier to the Washington County line at McDonald, is all but complete. West Virginia's section, about 5 miles from Weirton to the Pennsylvania line at Hanover, is complete.

Washington County has the missing link. Its 17.3 miles from McDonald to Hanover are undeveloped, except for the sixth-tenths-of-a-mile stretch in Mount Pleasant and Cecil that connects with nothing.

With much hoopla, that hastily constructed "demonstration project" about a half-mile from the McDonald trail station was opened in 1999 as the state's 100th rails-to-trails venture.

The opening came amid the last commissioners' campaign, striking some as a political stunt.

"Not a spade has been turned out there since," Burns said.

Cessna said the demonstration project gave people a sense of what was coming but false hope it could be done quickly. She and Bevec said

people don't understand the project's complexity.

The Panhandle Trail and the longer Montour Trail would intersect in a rural area a few hundred yards from the Panhandle demonstration project, creating the rails-to-trails equivalent of the Interstates 70/79 junction.

McDonald is poised to capture visitors from both trails and accordingly has been designated one of the state's five "trail towns" by the Allegheny Trail Alliance, an umbrella rails-to-trails group.

It wouldn't be the first time McDonald has had the role of junction and depot. The site of a American Indian trading post dating to 1775, the borough then "served as an important focal point during the great Western Pennsylvania oil, coal and railroad industry booms of the late 19th and early 20th centuries," according to information provided by the redevelopment association.

Trails do have economic benefits. For example, when fully developed, the 47-mile Montour Trail could generate more than \$800,000 a year for communities along the route, according to projections by Brad Clemenson, marketing committee chairman for the trail alliance and an aide to U.S. Rep. John Murtha, D-Cambria County.

Thomassy, a McDonald councilman and former Navy officer who commanded the aircraft carrier Forrestal, said a project with as much potential as the Panhandle Trail should be moving forward faster. That's Burns' point, too.

"It's not just recreation. ... It's economic development. It's wellness. It's a no-brainer for anybody who has a brain," Burns said.

Burns said he has struggled since his last term to bring the project to fruition, facing lack of interest sometimes from his colleagues and other times from planning department officials.

He lamented the firing of Baechle, who personally supported the project and worked to secure the railroad bed and funds for construction. When the balance of power shifted in January 2000, Burns said, Baechle was "on the wrong side" and got fired.

Burns said he doesn't believe his colleagues' statements that Baechle's position was one of several eliminated for financial reasons.

He said Baechle called him "practically in tears, saying, 'Commissioner, what did I do wrong?' " Baechle, recently hired as Allegheny County's parks director, could not be reached for comment.

Ned Williams, president of the Panhandle Trail Association, said the commissioners' "acrimony" toward each other probably slowed the project. However, he said, technical issues and the commissioners' full agenda played roles, too.

Cessna said new state rules for trail intersections with bridges have complicated the negotiation of an engineering contract. Also, she said

the county still is waiting for the state Public Utility Commission to approve the county's plan for handling trail intersections with bridges and roads.

Burns said such issues could have been surmounted by those with the will to do so. If he had been running the county the past 3 1/2 years, he said, construction would have occurred.

Thomassy said a man who had agreed to operate a concession stand at the trail station backed out because he wouldn't have many trail users for customers any time soon.

Meanwhile, there won't be an immediate need for the brochures the redevelopment group published with an \$1,800 grant from Allegheny Trail Alliance.

Thomassy's group had planned to put the brochures, showing the location of restaurants and other McDonald businesses, in the trail station to lure bicyclists and other trail users into town. The brochures should be in hand by the building's open house next Sunday.

Nor is there an immediate need for the bicycle racks, fabricated by welding shop students at Western Area Career and Technology Center, that the redevelopment group placed outside businesses.

Thomassy said a few trail users do come through town, on a makeshift route between the Montour Trail and Allegheny County's portion of the Panhandle Trail. But he said it's an unsafe route along busy Route 980, which has no berm.

Some trail enthusiasts fear Panhandle construction won't occur until 2005.

Williams and Thomassy want the county to begin work sooner, at least on an easily developable section of trail in the McDonald area, from the county line west to the demonstration project. That, Williams said, would give Panhandle users access to the trail station/meeting house and set the stage for the Panhandle's connection with the Montour Trail.

Cessna said she's willing to pursue that plan, perhaps using the county engineer to design the mile-plus section of trail. Thomassy said he's willing to husband equipment and volunteer labor to get the project going and pump life back into McDonald.

"When we grew up," he said, "McDonald was a very vibrant little town."

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